Presuppositional and Dynamic Aspects of Questions

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Domain of this PhD dissertation

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(1) a. How tall is this building?
b. How tall can this building be?

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b. How tall can this building be?

Domain: Semantics and pragmatics of questions

Impact of questions

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Topic: Presuppositions and anaphora of questions

Variation

(3) a. Who knows how Dutch water tax works?

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b. #She is very helpful.

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Goal: Explain this variation in presuppositions and anaphora with questions

My theory

Semantic reading ambiguity between who_S and who_G

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Semantic reading ambiguity between *who*$_S$ and *who*$_G$

Specific *who*$_S$

(4) Who was sitting there?

- Existential presupposition
- Anaphora with a pronoun

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Generic *who*$_G$

(5) Who knows how Dutch water tax works?

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- Anaphora but only under a modality

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Semantic reading ambiguity between *who*$_S$ and *who*$_G$

Specific *who*$_S$

(4) Who was sitting there?

- Existential presupposition
- Anaphora with a pronoun

Generic *who*$_G$

(5) Who knows how Dutch water tax works?

- No existential presupposition
- Anaphora but only under a modality

Arguments:

- Extends similar analyses used in declaratives
- Explains ambiguous cases

  (6) Who went in the cellar recently?

- Supported by interactions with generic terms, weak islands, focus, clefts, NPIs

Overview of the dissertation

1. Existential presuppositions of questions
2. Anaphora with *who*

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3. Questions with a modality

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(7) Depending on [how many people are coming], we might book several rooms.

Model: conditional with an embedded question, a modality, donkey anaphora and focus

Thank you!